

Mam's Irish Stew

From Kate's kitchen, by feel, written down so Emma has it.

Serves 6, a Sunday or a cold-snap dinner. Made from scratch, no shortcuts.

Ingredients

- 2.5 lb lamb shoulder (or neck), cut into chunks
- 2 large onions, sliced
- 5 to 6 carrots, thick coins
- 6 medium potatoes, halved (plus 2 extra, grated, to thicken)
- Small handful pearl barley
- Sprig of thyme, a bay leaf, parsley
- Beef or lamb stock to cover; salt and plenty of black pepper

Method

1. Brown the lamb in the cast-iron Dutch oven in batches. Do not crowd it.
2. Soften the onions in the same pot; scrape up the brown bits.
3. Return the meat, add carrots, potatoes, barley, herbs. Cover with stock.
4. Low and slow, 2 hours, lid on, barely bubbling. The grated potato melts in and thickens it.
5. Check seasoning at the end. Rest 10 minutes. Parsley on top.

Serve with soda bread and a strong pot of Irish breakfast tea. The slow way is the honest way.